

CHRYSANTHEMUM

Chrysanthemum morifolium / Dendranthema grandiflorum

Quick Facts

Scientific Name	Chrysanthemum morifolium / Dendranthema grandiflorum
Family	Asteraceae (Daisy family)
Common Names	Chrysanthemum, Mum, Shevanti (Marathi), Chandramallika (Hindi/Sanskrit), Sevanthi (Telugu/Kannada)
Native Origin	China and northeastern Europe; cultivated for over 2,500 years in East Asia
Colors	Yellow, white, orange, red, pink, bronze, purple, bi-coloured, and green. The yellow and orange forms are most common in Indian markets.
Height	30 cm to 150 cm depending on variety. Pot chrysanthemums are typically 30 to 45 cm; cut flower varieties can reach 120 cm.
Blooming Season	September to January in India, with peak flowering during October and November coinciding with Diwali and Kali Puja. Chrysanthemums are short-day plants — they initiate flowering when nights become longer than a critical length (around 13 hours), which naturally occurs in autumn in India.

Distribution in India

Grown extensively across India, especially in West Bengal (Kolkata and surroundings), Maharashtra, Karnataka, Tamil Nadu, Andhra Pradesh, and Madhya Pradesh. Commercial cultivation is concentrated around Pune, Bengaluru, and Navsari. Kolkata's flower market at Mullick Ghat handles massive chrysanthemum volumes for the autumn festival season.

Description and Overview

Chrysanthemum is one of the most commercially important ornamental flowers in India and globally. It belongs to the Asteraceae family and is a herbaceous perennial or annual depending on climate. The plant produces flower heads composed of many individual florets — tubular disc florets at the centre and ray florets (the apparent petals) around the outside. Different cultivars show extraordinary variation in head shape: single, semi-double, double, pompon, spider, quill, and incurved forms all exist.

The chrysanthemum has been cultivated in China since at least the 15th century BCE and holds tremendous cultural importance across East and South Asia. In China and Japan, it symbolises longevity and rejuvenation. In India, it has a strong association with the autumn festive season, particularly Diwali.

India is among the top producers of chrysanthemum globally, with West Bengal being historically the largest producing state. The Kolkata flower market, one of Asia's largest wholesale flower markets, sells hundreds of thousands of chrysanthemum stems daily during the October to December peak season. The flowers are used extensively in garlands, loose flower sales, and floral decorations for temples and homes.

The plant is a photoperiod-sensitive short-day plant, meaning it flowers only when night length exceeds approximately 13 hours. Commercial growers manipulate daylength with black curtains (to accelerate flowering) or artificial light (to delay it), allowing year-round production for export.

Blooming Season and Conditions

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Cultivation

Chrysanthemums are propagated by suckers, cuttings, or crown divisions. In India, planting is generally done between June and August for autumn bloom. The plant prefers well-drained, fertile loamy soil with a pH of 5.5 to 6.5. It requires adequate irrigation but does not tolerate waterlogging.

Regular pinching of the growing tips during the vegetative phase promotes bushy growth and multiple flower heads. Disbudding (removing secondary buds) is practised for large exhibition blooms. The plant is susceptible to aphids, thrips, and the fungal disease powdery mildew, which are major challenges in the humid Kolkata climate during the monsoon growing period.

Uses and Applications

Cut flowers: India's chrysanthemum cut flower industry is worth several hundred crore rupees annually. **Garlands and decorations:** Used extensively in religious offerings, wedding decorations, and festive garlands. **Herbal tea:** Dried chrysanthemum flowers are brewed into a calming, antioxidant-rich tea, particularly consumed across East and Southeast Asia. **Traditional medicine:** Used in Ayurveda for eye complaints, headaches, and fevers. **Insecticide:** Pyrethrin, a natural insecticide, is extracted from certain Chrysanthemum species (*Chrysanthemum cinerariifolium*).

Interesting Facts

- The chrysanthemum is one of the Four Noble Plants in Chinese culture, along with plum, orchid, and bamboo.
- It is Japan's national flower and appears on the Japanese Imperial Seal and on Japanese passports.
- In France, chrysanthemums are associated with funerals and should not be given as a gift in casual settings.
- Chrysanthemum tea is one of the most popular herbal teas in China and Vietnam, consumed for its cooling properties and mild sedative effect.
- India exports chrysanthemums to the Netherlands, Japan, and the Middle East, making it a significant foreign exchange earner in the floriculture sector.

Source: Flower AI Knowledge Base — CHRYSANTHEMUM entry. Scientific name: Chrysanthemum morifolium / Dendranthema grandiflorum. Family: Asteraceae (Daisy family).